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NEWM-N450

Evaluation

Mobile Application: TownHappening

Description: TownHappening is a mobile app prototype designed to help small town residents discover local events in one centralized location by aggregating event information from multiple platforms including Facebook, Instagram, and local government sites.

Target Demographics: Residents of small towns, particularly parents and community members aged 30-65 who use Facebook and Google to find local events.

Platform Evaluated: Mobile prototype tested in person using Marvel prototype on an Android phone.

Task-Based Scenario

Task: You are a resident of Hobart, Indiana looking for something fun to do this week. You heard there might be a local arts event happening soon but are not sure of the details. Using this app, find an event you would want to attend, save it to your favorites, and tell me what information you would need to actually show up.

Task Navigation: Open TownHappening mobile app → Browse home feed → Find an event of interest → Tap event card to open Event Detail screen → Review event details → Tap Save to add to Favorites → Navigate to Favorites screen to confirm saved event → Optional: Change location using the location header

User Testing Script

Introduction & Baseline (2 Minutes)

- "Hi [Participant Name], thank you so much for taking the time to help me out today. I am going to walk you through this session. Before we get started I want to give you some information about what we are doing today. I asked you here to try a prototype of a mobile app that I designed for one of my classes at IU. We are testing the app's layout and navigation, not your technical skills. The first thing I want to make clear is that we are testing the app, not you, so you cannot do anything wrong here."
- "As you go through this, please think aloud. Tell me what catches your eye, what you expect to happen when you tap something, what you are trying to do, and what you are thinking. If something is confusing or does not work the way you expected, please say that because it is actually the most helpful feedback I can get. If you have any questions we can address them when we are done. Is it okay if I take notes during the session? Do you have any questions before we get started?"
- "Before we start, I have a couple of quick questions:"
- "How old are you and what do you do for work?"
- "How often do you use your phone to look something up?"
- "How do you currently find out about local events in Hobart?"

Phase 1: Home Feed & Navigation (3-4 Minutes)

- *Hand the participant the phone with the TownHappening prototype open on the home screen.*
- "Take a look at this screen. What is your very first reaction to what you see?"
- "Without tapping anything yet, what do you think this app does based on what you see?"

- "Go ahead and look for an event where you would find paintings. Where does your eye go first?"
- *They should tap an event card to open the Event Detail screen.*
- "Is this what you expected to see after tapping that event?"

Phase 2: Event Detail & Saving (3-4 Minutes)

- *The Event Detail screen displays with date, time, location, attending count, description, Save and Share buttons.*
- "Take a look at this screen. What information do you see here?"
- "Is there anything you would want to know about this event that you do not see here?"
- "Go ahead and do whatever you would do next if you wanted to remember this event."
 - *They should tap the Save/Saved button.*
- "Was that what you expected to happen?"

Phase 3: Category Filtering (2-3 Minutes)

- "Now go back to the home screen. Imagine you are only interested in food events this week. Go ahead and try to find only food related events."
 - *They should tap the Food category chip.*
- "Did that work the way you expected?"
- "How useful do you think these category filters are for finding events you care about?"
- "Are there any categories you would want to see that are not currently there?"
- "Now tap All to go back to seeing all events."
 - *They should tap the All chip to reset the filter.*

Phase 4: Favorites & Location (3 Minutes)

- "Now go ahead and find where your saved events are stored."
 - *They should tap the Favorites nav at the bottom.*
- "Is this screen what you expected to see?"
- "Does having your saved events in one place feel useful to you?"
- "Now go back to the home screen. Imagine you are visiting a friend in a different town and want to find events there. See if you can change the location in the app."
 - *They should tap the Hobart, IN location in the header to trigger the Change Location dialog.*
- "Was it clear to you how to change the location?"
- "Did the dialog appear where you expected it to?"
- "Go ahead and type a new city and tap Save."
 - *They should type a city and tap Save.*
- "Was that process straightforward or did anything feel confusing?"

Wrap Up & Post-Test Questions (2-3 Minutes)

- "We are all done with the navigation! Before I let you go I have a few quick questions:"
 - 1) "On a scale of 1 to 5 (5 being very easy), how easy was it to find and save an event using this app?"
 - 2) "On a scale of 1 to 5, how confident did you feel navigating between screens?"
 - 3) "On a scale of 1 to 5, how likely would you be to use an app like this regularly in real life?"

- 4) "On a scale of 1 to 5, how intuitive was the category filter for finding specific events?"
 - 5) "On a scale of 1 to 5, how easy was it to change the location in the app?"
 - 6) "What was your favorite part of the app?"
 - 7) "What is one thing you would change or add?"
- "Is there anything else you want to share about your experience today?"
 - "That is everything I needed! Thank you so much for your time and feedback, it is truly helpful!"

Demographics of Participants

Participant 1: A 64-year-old, single mother of adult children in household size of 1. They have lived in town for 15 years and use smartphone daily for approximately 1 hour per day. Uses Facebook and Google to discover local events. They typically google a specific festival by name to find details, but only when they already know what they are looking for. They are triggered to search when bored or looking for something to do, and many events they attend are long-standing family traditions.

Participant 2: A 32-year-old observability engineer and parent who has lived in town for 6 years. They use Facebook daily, primarily for Marketplace. They find out about events through Facebook or physical signs around town and rely on the Facebook algorithm to surface local events, which they note is unreliable.

Participant 3: An 18-year-old student who uses their smartphone to search for events a few times a day. They primarily search uses google to search for events as they don't use social media.

Table Findings

User ID	Category	Phase/Screen	Problem	Tag 1	Tag 2
P1, p3	Visual Hierarchy	Change Location	The header was structurally backward; they expected title to sit above the location. P3 struggled to read on the low-fit prototype due to size/black and white color.	Minor	Usability/Layout
P1	Navigation	Favorites Screen	Return to home screen from Favorites was not immediate. The user paused and felt confused before they tapped Browse	Moderate	Usability
P1	Information Architecture	Favorites Screen	Experienced confusion regarding feature placement, questioned whether to keep category filter chips on this page was necessary.	Low	Utility/Clutter
P1, P3	Content	Event Detail	User noted that the text information was slightly insufficient for the location and would have liked to see full address.	Low	Data Utility
P2, P3	Content	Category Filter	Flagged a long-term data filtering limitation, expressing concern that a small, rigid list of category chips may fail to accurately classify nice or multi-genre community events	Low	Utility / Scalability
P3	Content	Event Detail	Information provided on the event detail screen leaves out minor community context, the user requested to see specific hosting organization or individual named on the page.	Low	Data Utility

User Ratings from Questionnaire (Quantitative Ratings)

User ID	Q1: Ease	Q2: Navigation	Q3: Use Regularly	Q4: Filters	Q5: Location Change
P1	5 / 5	5 / 5	4 / 5	5 / 5	4 / 5
P2	5 / 5	5 / 5	5 / 5	4 / 5	5 / 5
P3	4 / 5	5 / 5	5 / 5	5 / 5	4 / 5
Final Average	4.7 / 5	5 / 5	4.7 / 5	5 / 5	4.3 / 5

Summary

Overall, the evaluations for TownHappening successfully validated that a centralized community aggregator eliminates the high interaction cost of "digging" across fragmented communication channels. Participants overwhelmingly praised the mobile prototype's clean layout, simple search interface, and seamless operational flow, which was reflected in near-perfect quantitative scores across the board. The strong design of the navigation mechanics and the category filtering chips were highly complimented during the sessions. Ultimately, testing proved that the core application structure requires virtually no learning curve for users of varied technology habits, firmly establishing the app's real-world utility for small-town residents seeking to engage with local happenings.

While the baseline functionality scored remarkably well, the "think-aloud" feedback provided a clear roadmap for the upcoming high-fidelity iteration. The final design sprint will focus heavily on visual refinement rather than structural rebuilding, specifically targeting the visibility and text scaling of the header elements to ensure changing locations is entirely

effortless. By correcting the top-left layout stack, removing redundant filtering chips from auxiliary screens, and expanding text content parameters to include explicit hosting details, the final high-fidelity prototype will successfully transition from a low-fidelity framework into a polished, production-ready alpha release.